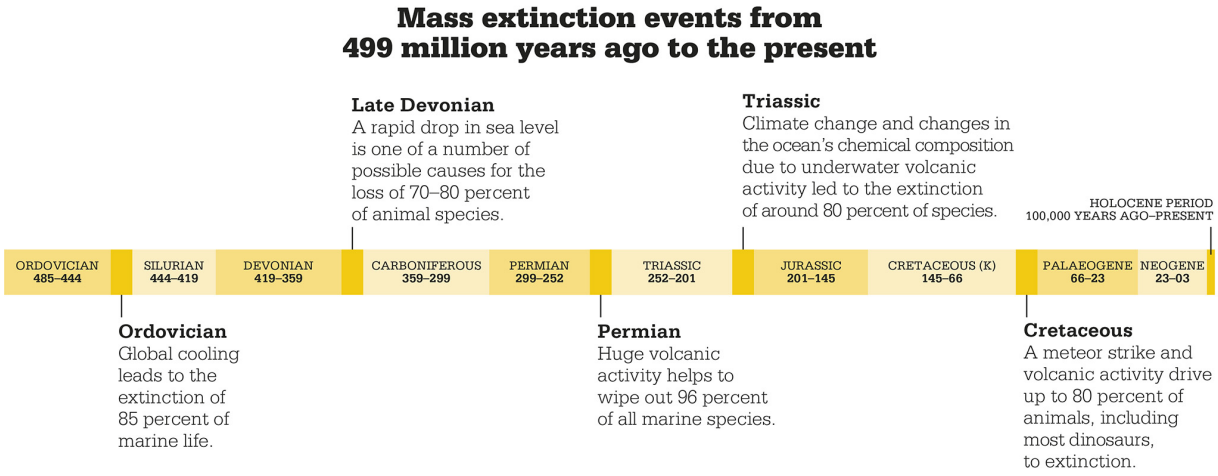


Read accessible description

"All geologic history is full of the beginnings and the ends of species–of their first and last days."

Hugh Miller

Scottish geologist

End of the dinosaurs

The mass extinction that scientists understand best is also the most recent, around 65 million years ago. Geologists refer to it as the K-Pg extinction event because it occurred at the end of the Cretaceous and start of the Palaeogene periods. Although an extraterrestrial origin was first suggested for the event in the 1950s, this was not taken seriously until two discoveries, in Europe and North America.

In 1980 a team of scientists working in Italy, including physicist Luis Alvarez and his geologist son, Walter Alvarez, discovered a clay layer between Cretaceous and Paleogene deposits. Examination of the clay revealed that it contained the mineral iridium, which is rare on Earth but common in asteroids. The discovery led to the Alvarez Hypothesis, which proposed that the extinction at the end of the Cretaceous period was caused by a catastrophic meteor strike. The location of the impact was still a